

ROAD TRIP EDITION

Oh Canada

Summer 2026 · Jun 25 – Jul 7 · Evanston, IL → Canada → home

~1,800

total miles (~2,900
km)

13

days on the road

3+2

US states + CA
provinces

10%

of Earth's fresh water
you'll drive past (Lake
Superior)

Thu, Jun 25 — Home → Cornell, WI

~5
hr ≈290 mi ·
I-90/94

Eat: Norske Nook in Osseo — award-winning Norwegian pie right off the highway. Get a slice (or a whole pie) for the road.

Dinner: Moonridge Brewing pizza in Cornell.

Camp: Brunet Island State Park — an island campground on the Chippewa; canoe the quiet lagoons and hit the swim beach.

Wild Things — Chippewa River country

- **Beaver:** the second-biggest rodent on Earth. Its orange front teeth are coated in **iron** (that's why they're orange) and **never stop growing** — if it didn't gnaw wood daily, its teeth would curl into its own skull. It eats bark and the soft layer underneath, not fish, and its lodge door is **underwater** so predators can't get in. **Gross bonus:** beavers mark territory with **castoreum**, a goo squeezed from sacs next to the butt — it smells like vanilla, and people used to put it in perfume and food flavoring.
- **River otter:** can hold its breath ~**8 minutes** and close its nose and ears underwater. The whole family shares one bathroom spot on the bank called a "**latrine**" — they poop in the same place on purpose to leave messages for other otters.
- **Bald eagle:** nests right on Brunet Island. Eagles build the **biggest tree nest of any North American bird** — up to **2 tons**, reused for years. They're also thieves: they'll dive-bomb an osprey and make it drop its fish in mid-air.
- **Lake sturgeon:** a living fossil swimming the Chippewa — armored in bony plates instead of scales, can live **100+ years** and grow over **6 feet**, and vacuums food off the river bottom with a tube-like mouth that has no teeth.

Did you know? — Chippewa Valley, WI

- Wisconsin is the "**Badger State**" — named not for the animal but for 1800s lead miners who dug into hillsides like badgers (the real badger is a stocky, bad-tempered digger that can tunnel out of sight in under a minute).
- Cornell has the **world's only surviving "pulpwood stacker"** — a 175-foot tower built in 1912 to pile logs for a paper mill.
- Nearby Chippewa Falls is home of **Leinenkugel's**, the 7th-oldest brewery in the US (1867), and the birthplace of **Seymour Cray**, the "father of the supercomputer."

Day 1 challenge — License Plate Bingo

Start your list. How many different states/provinces can you spot by the time you hit camp? First leg usually nets 8–12.

Fri, Jun 26 — Cornell → Ely, MN (through Duluth)

~4 ≈210
hr mi

Stop: Duluth Canal Park — eat with a Lake Superior view and watch the giant Aerial Lift Bridge raise for ships. Bonus climb: Enger Tower.

Near camp: the International Wolf Center & North American Bear Center in Ely — real wolves and bears.

Camp: Bear Head Lake State Park — swim and paddle a clear Northwoods lake ringed by pines.

Wild Things — Northwoods & Boundary Waters

- **Gray wolf:** Ely sits at the edge of the lower-48's biggest wolf country. A wolf can smell prey from **over 1.5 miles** away and gulp **~20 pounds of meat** in one sitting — that's where "wolfing it down" comes from. **Gross bonus:** parents can't carry groceries, so they swallow meat, trot back to the den, and **vomit it up** for the pups to eat. Their poop ("scat") is full of hair and crushed bone.
- **Moose:** the largest deer alive — taller than a horse. It eats **40–60 pounds of plants a day** and will **dive completely underwater**, closing its nostrils, to rip up plants from the lake bottom and hold its breath ~30 seconds. That flap of skin swinging under its throat is called a **"bell."**
- **Black bear:** before winter it eats up to **20,000 calories a day** (like 40 burgers). Then it dens for months without eating, drinking, peeing, or pooping — its body **recycles its own pee**, and a hard **"fecal plug"** seals its rear end shut the whole winter. Its nose is about **7× sharper than a bloodhound's**.
- **Common loon (MN state bird):** unlike most birds its bones are **solid, not hollow**, so it sinks and can dive **200 feet**. Its legs are set so far back it can barely walk on land and needs a **quarter-mile "runway"** of flapping across the water to take off. It swallows fish whole — and swallows small pebbles to grind food up in its gut.

Did you know? — Lake Superior & the Northwoods

- **Lake Superior is the largest freshwater lake on Earth by surface area** — it holds about **10% of all the planet's surface fresh water**, stays near **40°F** year-round, and is so big it makes its own fog and weather.
- It's also the **deepest** Great Lake — **1,333 ft (406 m)** straight down — and the **third-largest lake on Earth by volume**. There's enough water in it to cover **all of North AND South America** a foot deep.

- Out in the lake sits **Isle Royale**, home to the **longest-running wildlife study in the world** (since 1958): wolves vs. moose. The moose **swam ~15 miles** to get there, and the first wolves walked over on a winter **ice bridge**.
- Because it's so cold and deep, the lake **preserves shipwrecks** almost perfectly — sailors used to say "Superior never gives up her dead."
- Duluth is the **farthest-inland seaport in North America** — ocean ships sail **2,300+ miles** from the Atlantic to get there.

Spot it

Watch the water in Duluth for a "laker" — a freighter up to **1,000 feet long**. Call it out first and you win the round.

Sat, Jun 27 — Ely, MN → Sioux Narrows, ON

~5
hr ≈230 mi +
border

Photo stop: the giant Smokey Bear statue in International Falls before we cross.

Eat: Snackhouse in Sioux Narrows — burgers and fries.

Camp: Sioux Narrows Provincial Park — right on Lake of the Woods: swim, fish for walleye, watch the sunset over the islands.

Wild Things — Lake of the Woods & the Canadian Shield

- **American white pelican:** one of the biggest birds in North America, with a **9-foot wingspan** and a throat pouch that holds **3 gallons** of water. It doesn't dive — a whole line of pelicans **herds fish into the shallows** and scoops them up like nets. **Gross bonus:** a chick eats by shoving its **entire head down the parent's throat** to slurp out half-digested fish soup.
- **Walleye:** the fish this whole region is obsessed with. Its eyes have a mirror layer (like a cat's) that glows and lets it **hunt in the dark and in murky water** — which is exactly why its name is "wall-eye."
- **Snapping turtle:** too big to pull fully into its shell, so it defends itself by **biting** — a beak strong enough to take a finger. It eats almost anything, including dead stuff rotting on the lake bottom (nature's garbage crew).
- **Jack pine:** the scrappy tree clinging to the bare Shield rock. Its cones are **glued shut with resin and only pop open in a wildfire's heat** — so the tree literally needs forest fires to make baby trees.

Did you know? — The Border & the Shield

- Crossing into Ontario you roll onto the **Canadian Shield** — the **largest patch of exposed ancient rock on Earth**, covering about **half of Canada**. The bedrock is up to a few **billion** years old (the oldest, the Acasta Gneiss, is **~4 billion**), scraped bare by glaciers so the soil is paper-thin.
- Hidden in the Shield is the **Sudbury Basin** — a giant **meteorite crater** blasted out **1.85 billion years ago**. It's the **second-biggest impact crater on Earth**, you can see it from space, and the blast threw rock **all the way to Minnesota**. Apollo astronauts even trained there to learn to spot space rocks.
- **Lake of the Woods has 14,522 islands** — walk around all of them and you'd cover about **65,000 miles** of shoreline, more than twice around the planet. **Sioux Narrows**

sits right on it, and its rocky shores hide **ancient rock paintings (pictographs)** made by First Nations — some of the oldest in Canada.

- International Falls is nicknamed the "**Icebox of the Nation**" for some of the coldest winter temps in the continental US.

Border bonus

First country flip of the trip. New game: start spotting **Ontario** plates and Canadian road signs in **kilometres** — quick, what's 100 km/h in mph? (~62)

Sun, Jun 28 — Sioux Narrows → Victoria Beach, MB

~3.5
hr ≈250 km · all in
Canada

Stop: lunch in Kenora on the way — big dog-friendly patio at Yesterday's.

Arrive: the cottage! Stock up at the Victoria Beach general store. Treats: Le Gouter.

Wild Things — where the forest becomes prairie

- **Red-sided garter snake:** a couple hours from the cottage, near Narcisse, is the **biggest snake gathering on the planet** — limestone pits where up to **tens of thousands** of garter snakes pile up to survive winter. Every spring the males swarm each female into a writhing "**mating ball**" of dozens of snakes. By the time you visit in summer they've slithered out across the marshes to hunt frogs and worms.
- **Richardson's ground squirrel:** the "gophers" standing like little posts in the prairie fields. They **sleep through winter AND through the hottest part of summer** (that double nap is called estivation + hibernation), spending up to **9 months a year asleep underground**.
- **Red-tailed hawk:** watch the fence posts and sky over the open fields. It hunts by hovering, then drops on mice and gophers — and its eyesight is roughly **8× sharper than yours**.

Did you know? — Victoria Beach & Lake Winnipeg

- Out the window the rocky Canadian Shield **flattens into wide-open prairie** — the bottom of a giant Ice-Age lake (Lake Agassiz) that was once bigger than all the Great Lakes combined.
- Victoria Beach is the **only community in North America that bans private cars in July and August** — you park outside and walk, bike, or cab in.
- It sits on **Lake Winnipeg**, one of the **ten largest freshwater lakes in the world** — shallow, so it actually warms up enough to swim.

Landscape watch

Call the exact moment the rocky, tree-covered Shield turns into flat, treeless prairie. Whoever nails it gets shotgun next leg.

Mon Jun 29 – Thu Jul 2 — Cottage life, Victoria Beach

0 no driving — base
hr camp

Do: beach days, swimming, biking the car-free streets, and day trips — The Forks in Winnipeg (~1.5 hr) or Whiteshell/Pinawa hikes.

Treats: Le Gouter, Village Green Bakery, Salty's Drive-Inn.

Wild Things — lake, marsh & boreal forest

- **Great blue heron:** stalks the shallows on stilt legs, then **spears or snatches a fish and swallows it whole, headfirst** — sometimes a fish is so big it gets stuck and you can watch the lump go down its neck. **Gross bonus:** herons blast their poop backward away from the nest in a white "whitewash," and cough up **pellets** of bones and scales they can't digest.
- **Wood frog:** living in these woods is a frog with a superpower — in winter it lets **two-thirds of its body freeze solid. Its heart stops, it stops breathing**, and it pumps its blood full of natural antifreeze (sugar). In spring it thaws out and hops away, alive.
- **Common loon & muskrat:** listen at dusk for the loon's wail across the lake. In the reeds, muskrats build dome huts of mud and cattails and can **swim backward** and chew underwater without flooding their mouths.
- **The rock itself:** the pink-and-gray granite around the Whiteshell is **billion-year-old Shield bedrock** flecked with sparkly quartz and dark red garnet crystals — worth a close look on a bored afternoon.

Did you know? — Manitoba

- **Winnie-the-Pooh is named after Winnipeg.** In 1914 a Canadian soldier, Harry Colebourn, bought a real **black bear cub**, named her "Winnie" after his hometown, and gave her to the London Zoo — where she inspired the stories.
- The nearby **Whiteshell** has ancient Indigenous **petroforms** — rocks laid out into shapes of snakes, turtles, and people, some thousands of years old.
- Manitoba is nicknamed the **"Land of 100,000 Lakes"** — even more than Minnesota claims.

Cottage challenge

Four days, no car. Goals: swim every day, find a chunk of garnet-flecked granite, and hear a loon call after dark.

Fri, Jul 3 — Victoria Beach → Williams, MN

~4
hr ≈250 km · back to the
USA

Eat: Lake of the Woods Pizza Company in Baudette.

Camp: Zippel Bay State Park — walk the white-sand beach and the stone jetty out into Lake of the Woods; scan for piping plovers.

Wild Things — Zippel Bay & Lake of the Woods

- **Piping plover:** Zippel Bay's white-sand beach is one of only **four places in the whole region** this tiny endangered shorebird still nests. When a fox or gull gets near its eggs, the parent fakes a **"broken wing,"** flopping away pretending to be hurt to lure the predator off — then flies away fine.
- **Sandhill crane:** nests on the north side of the bay and stands over **4 feet tall**. **Gross bonus:** cranes **paint themselves** — they smear mud and rusty iron from the soil onto their feathers to dye gray into camouflage-brown. Their bugling call carries **2.5 miles**, and they'll happily eat other birds' eggs.
- **Also watch for:** white pelicans, bald eagles, river otters, and — back in the woods — timber wolves and moose, all of which live around this park.

Did you know? — Warroad, Roseau & Baudette

- **Lake of the Woods** — the giant lake you're camping on — touches **three places at once** (Minnesota, Ontario, and Manitoba). It's mostly shallow (~26 ft) but drops to **210 ft** deep, and people call it **"the other Great Lake."**
- Baudette is the **"Walleye Capital of the World,"** guarded by **Willie the Walleye**, a 40-foot, 2½-ton fish statue.
- **Warroad is "Hockeytown USA"** — a tiny town that's sent players to multiple Olympics — and **Roseau is the birthplace of the snowmobile.**
- Just east is the **Northwest Angle** — the only piece of the lower-48 US north of the Canada line, and you can only drive to it **through Canada.**

Statue selfie

Willie the Walleye is begging for a photo. Bonus points for the most dramatic "I caught it" pose.

Sat, Jul 4 — Williams → Two Harbors, MN

~4.5
hr ≈250 mi · July
4th

Stop: Bemidji — photo with the giant Paul Bunyan & Babe the Blue Ox.

Eat: Black Woods Grill or Lake Superior Burger Co. Sweet: Betty's Pies.

Camp: Gooseberry Falls State Park — walk the Upper, Middle & Lower Falls and hunt agates on the Lake Superior shore.

Wild Things — North Shore cliffs

- **Peregrine falcon:** nests on the North Shore's lava cliffs and is the **fastest animal alive** — it folds its wings and dives ("stoops") at over **200 mph**, then punches its prey out of the air. To keep that 200-mph wind from blowing its lungs apart, it has tiny bony cones inside its nostrils that slow the air down — the same idea engineers later copied for jet engines.
- **Lake Superior agate:** Minnesota's state gem — banded red-and-orange stones that formed as **quartz filled gas bubbles** inside the cooling lava a billion years ago, then got tumbled smooth by glaciers. Finding one is a real trophy. Hunt the gravel beach at Gooseberry.
- **Black bear:** common all along the North Shore. **Gross bonus:** a bear's poop changes color with the season — dark from meat and bugs in spring, then purple and seedy from gorging on berries in late summer.

Did you know? — Bemidji & the North Shore

- Bemidji calls itself the **"first city on the Mississippi River"** — here the giant river is just a shallow stream you could wade across.
- The North Shore cliffs are ~**1.1-billion-year-old lava flows** from a time when North America almost ripped in half (the Midcontinent Rift).
- Bemidji built the Paul Bunyan & Babe statues back in **1937**.

Agate hunt

Gooseberry Falls drops over ancient lava ledges. While you're there, hunt the shoreline — first to find a real banded agate wins.

Sun, Jul 5 — Two Harbors → Brule, WI

~1.5
hr ≈75 mi · short
day!

Stop: Split Rock Lighthouse — one of the most photographed spots on Lake Superior, perched on a 130-foot cliff.

Eat: Kro Bar in Brule, or a Culver's/A&W run in Superior.

Camp: Brule River State Forest — the ice-cold, spring-fed "River of Presidents"; great for wading and rock-flipping.

Wild Things — the Brule River

- **Brook trout:** the Brule is spring-fed and ice-cold, which is exactly what trout need — they can only survive in **clean, cold, oxygen-rich water**, so a healthy trout stream is proof the water is pure. They eat drifting bugs and will leap clear out of the water to grab a fly.
- **Leech:** yes, the northwoods lakes have them. **Gross bonus:** a leech has **three jaws with ~100 tiny teeth**, and its spit contains a chemical that **stops blood from clotting** so it can keep feeding — doctors still use real leeches in surgery today. (Cold-blooded fact: most lake leeches actually eat snails and bugs, not people.)
- **Crayfish:** the mini-lobsters under the rocks. They can **drop a claw to escape a predator** and grow it back, and they swim **backward** by flipping their tail. Flip a rock in the shallows and you'll find one.

Did you know? — Split Rock & the Brule

- **Split Rock Lighthouse** exists because a single furious storm in November **1905 wrecked or damaged 29 ships** on Lake Superior in one night.
- The most famous wreck of all, the **Edmund Fitzgerald**, sank in a Lake Superior storm on **Nov 10, 1975** with all **29 crew** — its last radio words were "We are holding our own." A famous song was written about it, and an estimated **550 shipwrecks** rest on the lake's bottom.
- The spring-fed Brule drops **420 feet** on its way to Lake Superior, making tons of rapids — and it's the "**River of Presidents**," where five US presidents fished.
- Watch the Split Rock cliffs for nesting **peregrine falcons and ravens** riding the wind off the lake.

Free time

Shortest drive of the trip = most goofing-off time. Lighthouse photo, skip rocks, hunt more agates, flip rocks for crayfish.

Mon, Jul 6 — Brule → Wisconsin Dells / Mirror Lake

~4
hr ≈240 mi
south

Eat: a second Norske Nook pie hit in Osseo is fair game.

Afternoon: Wisconsin Dells — the "Waterpark Capital of the World." Dinner: Grateful Shed food hall or Brat House Grill.

Camp: Mirror Lake State Park — calm, glassy water under sandstone bluffs; swim or paddle before the Dells.

Wild Things — Baraboo & the Dells gorge

- **Cranes:** nearby Baraboo has the **International Crane Foundation — the only place on Earth you can see all 15 species of crane**. The whooping crane, the tallest bird in North America, dropped to about **15 birds left alive in 1941**, and this place helped bring it back from the edge.
- **The gorge:** the Dells is a 5-mile canyon of **500-million-year-old sandstone** — packed sand from an ancient sea — that got blasted open **~15,000 years ago** when a glacier-dammed lake burst and a wall of meltwater tore through in days.
- **Little brown bat:** Wisconsin's caves and bluffs are full of them. One bat eats up to **1,000 mosquito-sized bugs an hour** at night, finding them in total darkness by **echolocation** — screaming and listening for the echo.

Did you know? — Wisconsin Dells & Baraboo

- The land along the Dells is sacred to the **Ho-Chunk Nation**, whose ancient burial mounds — many shaped like animals — remain nearby.
- Next-door **Baraboo is the birthplace of the Ringling Brothers Circus** (1884) — now a museum with **260+ antique circus wagons**.
- The sandstone here is soft enough to carve with a fingernail, which is why the river cut it into such crazy cliffs and pillars.

Final tally

Pull out the license-plate list — how many states/provinces did you bag over 13 days?
Beat 25 and it's an all-timer.

Tue, Jul 7 — Dells → Home

~2.5
hr ≈170 mi · last
leg

Eat: Madison for a real lunch, or grab-and-go.

Wild Things — prairie & farm country home

- **Sandhill crane:** scan the cut farm fields of southern Wisconsin — flocks of these tall gray cranes feed here, and they're one of the **oldest bird types on Earth**, basically unchanged for millions of years.
- **Turkey vulture:** the dark V-winged bird rocking side to side over the highway. It finds dead animals by **smell from a mile up**, and pulls two of the grossest defense moves around: it **pees down its own legs to cool off**, and when threatened it **projectile-vomits** a foul, half-digested slurry at the attacker.
- **Home stretch:** as the prairie returns, you're crossing the flat bed of an ancient glacial lake again — the same kind of landscape that started flattening out back in Manitoba.

Did you know? — Madison & home

- Wisconsin's capital, **Madison, is built on a narrow isthmus** — a skinny strip of land squeezed between two lakes.
- The State Capitol dome is the **only granite dome in the US**, and by law no downtown building may be taller than it.
- Cross back into Illinois — the **"Prairie State"** — and you're almost home.

Last call

Each person names their #1 animal sighting AND #1 moment of the whole trip. No repeats.

Trip-long Creature Quest

- **Spot-it scorecard:** 1 pt for a chipmunk/squirrel, 2 for a deer, 3 for a bald eagle or great blue heron, 5 for a loon, beaver, otter, or pelican, 10 for a moose, bear, wolf, fox, or sandhill crane. Keep a running tally per person.
- **Gross-out leaderboard:** each day, whoever finds the grossest *real* nature fact (scat, vomit, parasites, etc.) wins the round. The whitewash heron, the bear's fecal plug, and the puking vulture are the ones to beat.
- **Track & sign hunt:** you don't need to see the animal — score for finding tracks, chewed beaver sticks, an owl pellet, a feather, or fresh scat.
- **Agate trophy:** first to find a real banded Lake Superior agate (Jul 4–5) is the trip's official Rock Champion.

Road-trip games for the long stretches

- **License Plate Bingo:** log every state/province you spot. Goal for the trip: 25+. Ontario and Manitoba plates count double.
- **20 Questions / Animal-Mineral-Vegetable:** classic, works anywhere, no signal needed.
- **The Alphabet Game:** find A→Z in order on road signs, plates, and billboards. Q and X are brutal.
- **Padiddle:** first to spot a car with one headlight out (after dark) calls it.
- **Would You Rather — Canada edition:** wrestle a moose or out-swim a muskie? Get chased by a wolf pack or a swarm of mating garter snakes? Defend your answer.
- **Fact-off:** use this page. Quiz each other on the "Wild Things" facts — loser picks the next snack stop's playlist.
- **Two Truths and a Lie:** make one up using a trip fact and see who gets fooled.